

Earthworm Identification Guide

This guide can be used for the OPAL Soil and Earthworm Survey



↓ **Start here** ↓
Note that line drawings show the typical sizes of adult earthworms

Is it more than 2cm long, **AND** does it have a clearly developed saddle?



The saddle is usually a different colour to the rest of the body, and slightly wider

Yes

Is the whole body clearly stripy on its upper surface when moving?



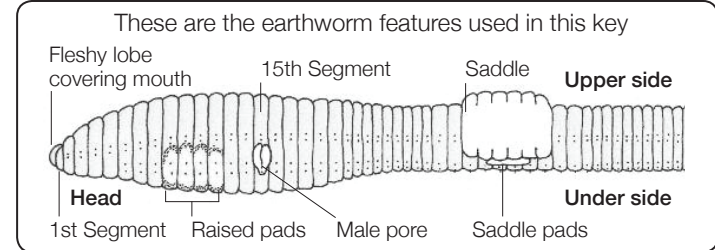
No

Yes

Is it greenish?

No

Yes



No

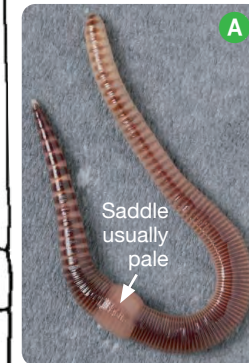
It is not a mature earthworm - you can't identify it with this Guide. At least 50% of the earthworms you find will be immature

Stripy earthworms

Which description best matches your worm? Is the body:

A

Longer and wider or **B** Shorter and narrower?



Saddle usually pale

1. Compost worm *Eisenia veneta*

B

Saddle usually similar colour to the rest of the body



Hint
Can exude an unpleasant smelling yellowish fluid when handled

2. Brandling worm *Eisenia fetida*



3. Green worm (green form) *Allolobophora chlorotica*



Hints

Often curls up in the hand
Yellow ring on body
Has 3 pairs of sucker-like discs (see 13)
Can exude a yellow fluid when handled

5. Black-headed worm *Aporrectodea longa*

A

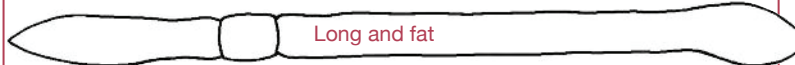
Hint
Often a dark purplish head, the rear end of the body is much paler



Long and thin

Which description best matches your worm? Is the body:

A Long and relatively thin or **B** Long and relatively fat?



Long and fat

B

Sometimes it flattens its tail into a wide paddle shape



Hint
A stout worm, often as thick as a pencil

6. Lob worm *Lumbricus terrestris*

Yes

Are the male pores visible?



No

4. Redhead worm *Lumbricus rubellus*

Key continues on the other side

Yes

Is the earthworm longer than 8cm when NOT moving?

No

Red earthworms

Yes

Is the upper surface of the body, from the first segment to the saddle, entirely dark in colour (dark red, purplish red or chestnut brown)?

No



No

Is the body from the first segment to the saddle partly or entirely pale in colour (whitish, pink or grey)? It may have some reddish or dark segments

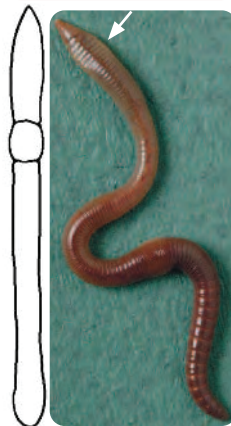


Yes

Pale earthworms

Key continues on the other side

Hint
Sometimes slightly flattens its tail into a paddle shape



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10. Rosy-tipped worm *Aporrectodea rosea*

Hints

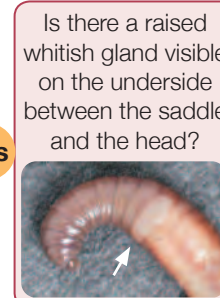
The head is usually rosy pink or pale pink up to the male pores
 Often has 2 or more whitish raised pads before the male pores. The saddle is usually orange, and can be wider towards the rear end



7. Octagonal-tailed worm *Dendrobaena octaedra*



8. Chestnut worm *Lumbricus castaneus*



Is there a raised whitish gland visible on the underside between the saddle and the head?

Yes

No

Yes

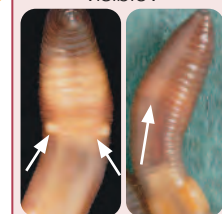
Is the swelling around the male pore only covering one segment?

No

No

Yes

Are the male pores visible?



Visible Not visible

You have probably found a rare worm which is not in this key. Record it as unidentified

No

Yes

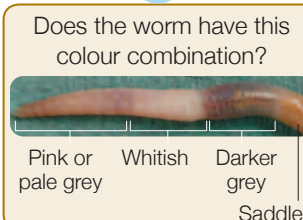
Is the swelling around the male pores broad, covering the entire width of adjacent segments?



Red earthworms



9. Little tree worm *Satchellius mammalis*



Does the worm have this colour combination?

Pink or pale grey Whitish Darker grey Saddle

No

Yes

No

Does it have a yellow ring towards the head?

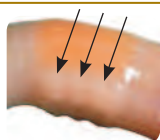
Yes

No



Tail not yellow or only slightly yellow
 Are the last four or five segments distinctly yellow?
 Distinct yellow tail

Yes



Hints

Has 3 pairs of sucker-like discs on the underside of alternate segments of the saddle, not always easy to see. The yellow ring can be faint
 Often curls up in the hand
 Can exude a yellow fluid when handled



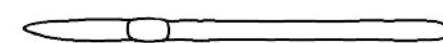
13. Green worm (pale form) *Allolobophora chlorotica*



Hints
 The front end up to the saddle is usually in three distinct shades: pink or pale grey, then whitish, and then darker grey
 The saddle pads usually form a two-humped ridge across three segments, but these can be difficult to see



11. Grey worm *Aporrectodea caliginosa*



Pale earthworms



12. Blue-grey worm *Octolasion cyaneum*



Hints
 Distinct yellow tail
 Can vary from faint blue-grey to a pale rosy pink colour
 May have a lilac-blue line on the upper surface

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 cm